FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The world is in upheaval. International relations are mercurial at best. Everyone is trying to navigate a phase where 'known knowns' are in rapid mutation, constancy in friendship is as rare as a critical mineral, and only hard-nosed realism prevails as the organising principle. But even in such circumstances, one old motto helps deliver a path along which to plan one's steps: national interest is permanent. And if that overlaps for two countries on a basket of exigencies substantial and urgent enough, we can have a deal. The message from Washington DC, delivered by the visiting Secretary of State Marco Rubio, is this: India and the United States are precisely in such a happy zone of overlapping needs. There may be pain points on certain issues, but our interests converge more than they diverge, that too on issues neither side can let go of. In an exclusive interview to INDIA TODAY, reassurance was the strongest leitmotif and an imminent India-US trade deal the clearest news signal. Long in gestation and bogged down by details, the deal is in the last stages of getting to a form "beneficial to both countries", Rubio said. "In five years, we'll look back and say it's one of the strongest relationships in the world."

The 55-year-old Secretary of State was joined by US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor, a rare joint interview, as he spoke to Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa at the close of a three-day official visit that saw him touch base in Mumbai and Jamnagar, engaging in high-level diplomatic and corporate discussions. The venue, Taj Mahal Palace in Mumbai, a high-profile target during the 26/11 terror attacks, lent depth to the best one-liner Rubio offered: "It's a logical partnership." Terrorism is an area where the two countries are naturally aligned. But it is also a context that supplies the complication. How strong can a partnership be when its participants cultivate other relationships that make either side uncomfortable? US president Donald Trump's unilateral claim that he brokered the India-Pakistan ceasefire during Operation Sindoor had caused discomfiture in New Delhi, and was a notable sticking point in Indo-US ties in 2025. Washington's warmth towards Field Marshal Asim Munir added another problematic layer.

That aside, US actions in the Trump era have been riddled with punitive actions that sit uneasily with the idea of a partnership: a 50 per cent tariff, including penalties for buying Russian oil, and a $100,000 fee on H-1B visas that hurts Indians the most. On India's side, potentially causing unease in Washington, there is its insistence on strategic autonomy in foreign relations. India wants to pursue energy sufficiency on its own terms, and the wobble in ties saw New Delhi schmoozing with BRICS as a matter of multilateral hedging.



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Secretary Rubio has a persuasive, realistic argument in response that accommodates differences within a larger framework of necessity. No one could expect Washington to dilute its 'America First' priorities, he said; it is a pillar of Trumpian policy and not especially directed at India, even if it is impacted by some of them. India will always put its national interest first, he pointed out. Likewise, "I also hope everyone understands that the US under President Trump is going to put our people first, our workers first, and our country first. Where friends can work together is when…our existing common interests, our longstanding relationship, and our shared values allow us to work through some of those differences to reach outcomes that are positive for both countries."

If the immediate test is the trade deal, whose details Rubio declined to divulge, the real pivot of the emerging convergence is energy. He rationalised India's "diversification" imperative beyond what it is normally taken to mean. "It's not so much about buying less Russian oil than about buying more US crude or Venezuelan…." Rubio's visit to Reliance's Jamnagar refinery reflects that calculation. India's refining capacity could help process more western-hemisphere crude. Venezuelan crude, especially, is known for being heavy and viscous, hindering its immediate deployment to stabilise war-driven price fluctuation. So, when Rubio says, "It's in India's interest to diversify its portfolio", it means making it an active player, not merely a passive net buyer. The rest of the geopolitical orientation is both set by this novel turn and derives its logic from this code of mutual benefit. Rubio marked out cooperation in preventing a concentration of resources like critical minerals, saying: "We do not want to be overly dependent on any country. I am not singling out China." Ambassador Gor also ticked Indian investment in the US that is "creating jobs in local communities for Americans" as a similar "win-win" quid pro quo where "we have American companies that have moved here, especially relating to IT". AI, biomedicine, pharma, the list of items for potential reciprocity is long. This is the new security paradigm, then, where geo-economic security is increasingly the driver; defence cooperation, instruments like the Quad and "values" conditionals that reinforce that imperative. Will courtship around commerce work? Well, predictability is its biggest prerequisite. Judge the odds by this: the one thing predictable about Trump is his unpredictability.

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